> the event of the invasion … with the use of tactical nuclear weapons … I wish we had had the tactical nuclear weapons. It would have been wonderful. We wouldn't have rushed to use them, you can be sure of that. The closer to Cuba the decision of using a weapon effective against a landing, the better. Of course, after we had used ours, they would have replied with, say, 400 tactical weapons – we don't know how many would have been fired at us. In any case we were resigned to our fate. [83]

Dr Guevara also wrote of his willingness to travel the 'path of liberation even when it may cost millions of atomic victims' – a view, perhaps, at variance with the requirement of the Hippocratic Oath that doctors should 'do no harm'. In his autobiography, Castro provided a more reflective and critical attitude to nuclear war.[84]

Moscow planned to transfer nuclear-armed Luna missiles to the Cuban army.[85] No details of agreed command and control arrangements have emerged, but the Soviets intended to hand over nuclear warheads to the Cubans. The Lunas had ranges of only thirty miles or so (but could still have targeted Guantánamo). The realisation that there were Cuban fingers on nuclear triggers would surely have created a new crisis in the Caribbean.

In November Khrushchev changed his mind about transferring the Lunas. He became thoroughly exasperated by Castro's behaviour and was still mindful of Castro's exhortations about nuclear war on 27 October. According to Sergo Mikoyan's account (posthumously published in 2012), his father, Anastas Mikoyan, then played an intriguing diplomatic role in ensuring that Cuba did not acquire nuclear weapons.[86] The Soviet deputy premier had been tasked by the Presidium with repairing the damage to relations between Havana and Moscow after Khrushchev had unilaterally announced the withdrawal of the MRBMs. Mikoyan's efforts extended over three weeks in November 1962 (during which he missed his wife's death and her funeral). His aim was to persuade Castro to agree to the withdrawal of the Ilyushn-28s, which Washington had decided was integral to the agreement between Kennedy and Khrushchev. He eventually succeeded,